
Hunting-Season Shoulder Reset

What hours in a tree stand and hauling out a deer
does to your shoulder — and how to undo it

NATE RATCLIFF, LMT

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HEALING HANDS BY NATE

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Introduction

A BETWEEN SESSIONS BONUS PROTOCOL FOR everyone who sits cold-still in a stand and then drags out 150 pounds.

Hunting season. You sat in a tree stand for four hours in 35-degree weather without moving, then hauled 150 pounds out of the timber. And you're wondering why your shoulder is angry.

Every November I see the same client three or four times. Hunter, mid-40s to mid-60s, comes in with one-sided shoulder pain that he can't trace to any specific moment. He didn't fall. He didn't lift wrong. He just feels like his right shoulder is locked up and stiff, especially after the season starts.

The answer is almost always the same. Hunting is harder on your body than most people give it credit for. It's not a "passive activity" — sitting still in cold for hours under load IS the activity, and it has predictable consequences.

This protocol is for the day you come down out of the stand.

CHAPTER 1

What hunting actually does to your shoulder

THREE THINGS, IN COMBINATION, HIT YOUR shoulder during a typical hunt:

1. Unilateral rifle carry

You carry a rifle on one side — usually your dominant side, slung over your shoulder, gripped with one hand. That's an asymmetric load on your shoulder girdle, sometimes for an hour or more of hiking in or out.

The shoulder muscles on the loaded side work harder. The neck muscles on that side brace to support the head against the off-center weight. Over a multi-hour outing, you've put one side of your upper body through a low-grade endurance event that the other side didn't experience.

2. Cold + stillness

Sitting in a tree stand at 35 degrees, mostly motionless for 3-4 hours, is a recipe for muscle tightness. Cold reduces blood flow to surface muscles. Stillness means no warming activity. Your shoulder and neck

muscles slowly tighten over the duration of the sit, and by the time you're ready to climb down, the tissue is short, cold, and stiff.

Most muscle strains during hunting happen NOT during the act of shooting — but during the climb down or the immediate post-sit movement, when cold-stiff tissue is suddenly asked to perform.

3. Recoil + haul-out

If you take a shot, the recoil sends a sudden compressive force through your shoulder. One shot rarely causes problems. Multiple shots, season after season, can accumulate.

Then the haul-out. Dragging a deer through the timber, often uphill, often with a one-handed grip, is a brutal full-body asymmetric load. Your shoulders, traps, low back, and grip all take the work.

By the end of opening weekend, your shoulder girdle has had an unusual, asymmetric, intense workout that your body didn't train for.

CHAPTER 2

Pre-hunt warm-up (don't skip this)

IF YOU ONLY ADOPT ONE HABIT FROM THIS PROTOCOL, make it this: warm up before you climb into the stand. Five minutes.

Doesn't have to be elaborate. Just enough movement to bring blood flow and mobility to the muscles you're about to ask to sit motionless for hours.

At the truck before walking in:

- 10 arm circles each direction
- 10 shoulder shrugs (up to ears, hold, drop)
- 5 each-direction torso twists
- 5 cat-cow if you can (or a few good torso rotations standing)
- Roll your neck gently a couple of times

That's it. Five minutes. The difference between climbing down sore and climbing down fine.

Older hunters figured this out generations back — "limber up before you go in" wasn't just advice, it was experience.

CHAPTER 3

The post-hunt 5-move shoulder reset

AFTER YOU COME DOWN OUT OF THE STAND (OR finish the haul-out), do this. Five minutes. Five moves. Same day, not the next morning.

1. Arm circles

Stand with arms out to the sides. 10 small circles forward, 10 backward, then 10 big circles each direction.

Get the shoulder joints moving through their full range after hours of being mostly still.

2. Cross-body shoulder stretch

Reach your right arm across your chest. Use your left hand to pull it gently closer to your body. Hold 30 seconds. Switch sides.

Targets the back of the shoulder, which gets tight from holding the rifle position.

3. Doorframe chest stretch

Stand in a doorframe. Forearms on the frame, elbows at 90 degrees. Step one foot through the doorway. Lean forward gently.

30 seconds. This opens the chest after hours of arms-forward (whether bracing the rifle or just sitting hunched in cold).

4. Pendulum swings (the rotator cuff release)

Lean forward, support yourself with one hand on a sturdy surface (truck tailgate, table). Let your other arm hang straight down.

Make small circles with the hanging arm — 10 clockwise, 10 counterclockwise. Then small swings forward and back, then side to side.

This decompresses the rotator cuff after the loaded-shoulder time. Most hunters find this surprisingly relieving.

Switch sides.

5. Neck rotations + tilts

Slow neck rotations, both directions. Then ear-to-shoulder tilts on each side, 15 seconds each.

The neck took load from supporting your head against the rifle's off-center weight. Restore range of motion.

CHAPTER 4

End-of-day extras for haul-out days

IF YOU ACTUALLY GOT SOMETHING AND HAULED it out, your low back and grip took extra abuse beyond what the post-hunt sequence addresses. Add:

For the low back: Child's pose for 1 minute. Knees-to-chest on your back for 30 seconds. Spinal twist on your back, 30 seconds each side.

For the grip: Open and close your hands 20 times. Roll your forearms on a tennis ball, 30 seconds each side. Stretch your fingers wide, then make fists, 10 times.

Add another 3-4 minutes for these. Worth it.

CHAPTER 5

Why this matters for long-term hunting

IF YOU HUNT FOR DECADES, THE CUMULATIVE shoulder load is real. The hunters in their 60s and 70s on my table who can still hunt comfortably are almost universally the ones who treat the recovery as part of the activity, not as an afterthought.

Five minutes after each hunt. Three or four sessions in a season. The difference between hunting comfortably into your 70s and giving it up at 60.

CHAPTER 6

Closing

WARM UP BEFORE YOU GO UP, MOVE WHEN YOU come down. Your shoulders are doing more work during hunting season than you think.

The recovery work for hunting is short, specific, and reliably effective. Most hunters never do it because nobody told them they should. Now you know. Five minutes after each sit. Your shoulders will hold up.

See you on the table after the season — but only if you actually need to come in, which you might not.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,
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